

Visualising Endometriosis Pain Using Materials

The Language of
ENDOMETRIOSIS



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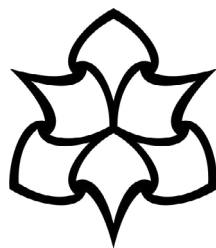
This booklet is based on the outputs of a workshop, organised by The Language of Endometriosis project at Manchester Metropolitan University, in which women with endometriosis used materials to help visualise, demonstrate and articulate their pain.

Research Team

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**Manchester
Metropolitan
University**

Previous research we conducted found that women with endometriosis feel that they do not have the appropriate tools to describe their pain and often feel that their pain is normalised (as 'just period pain') or dismissed entirely by both their own social circles, as well as by medical professionals.

The difficulty with describing pain is that it is invisible to those around you and you must rely on language to outwardly express your internal experience. In order to do this, we found that women use three types of metaphors to describe their pain:

Pain as physical damage

- # Pain that is akin to somebody or something causing physical damage to you using objects (for example: stabbing) or performing actions (for example: strangling)

Pain as physical properties of elements

- # Pain that is akin to pressure, weight, high temperature etc. (for example: 'an inflated balloon inside my tummy')

Pain as a transformative force

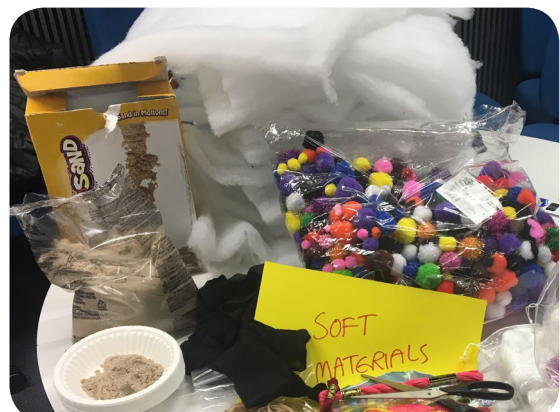
- # Pain that is made akin to an unknown force or agent taking control (for example: 'I feel outside of my brain')

Why a materials workshop?

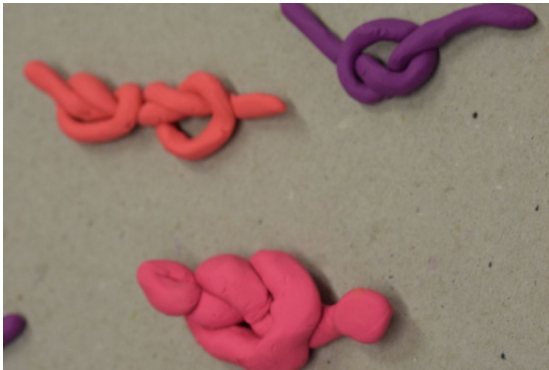
- # We wanted to explore whether a hands-on practice-based approach can help articulate pain
- # We wanted to see if there is a relationship between verbal metaphors for endometriosis pain and visual metaphors for endometriosis pain

In order to do this, we had women use various materials for different activities to see how they visualised their endometriosis pain.

We provided a variety of hard materials, such as metal offcuts, wire, pegs, pins, paper clips, chicken wire etc. and a variety of soft materials, such as plasticine, cotton wool, tights, balloons, wadding, and wool thread etc.



The activities



Activity 1: Think of one element of your pain and try to re-enact it (motion, action, manipulation etc.) using plasticine

Plasticine representing 'twisting', 'pulling' and 'things going in a direction that they shouldn't be'

Activity 2: How do the hard and soft materials interact with each other and how can you use them to describe / re-enact your pain?



Chicken wire (hard) vs. plasticine (soft) representing 'grating pain'

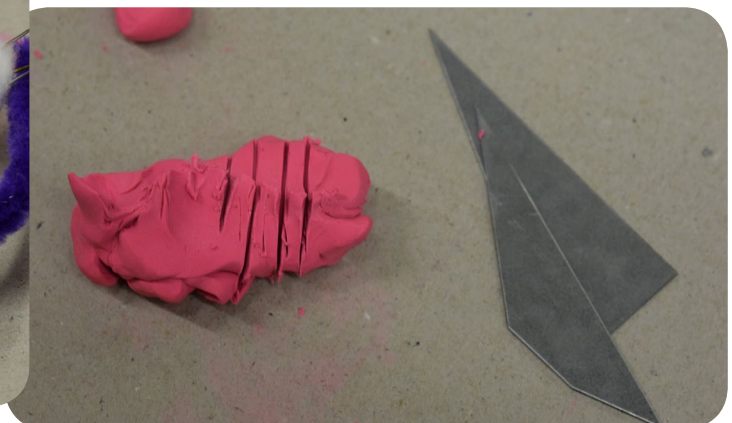
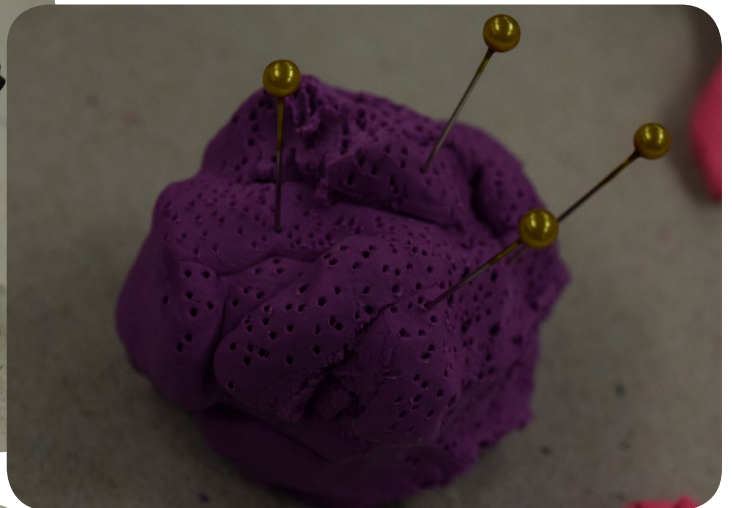
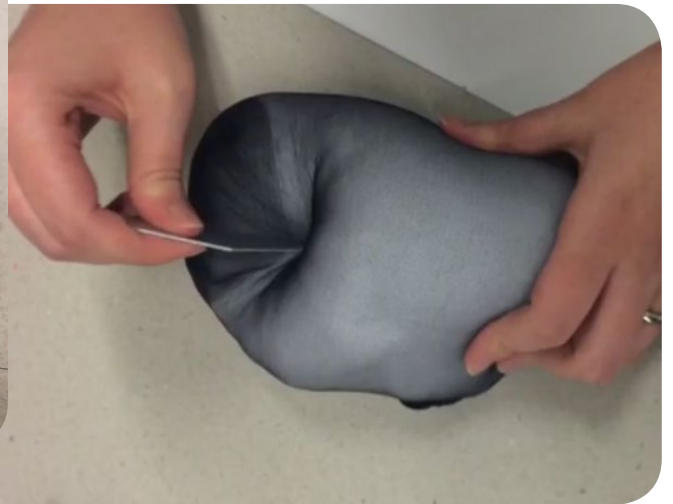
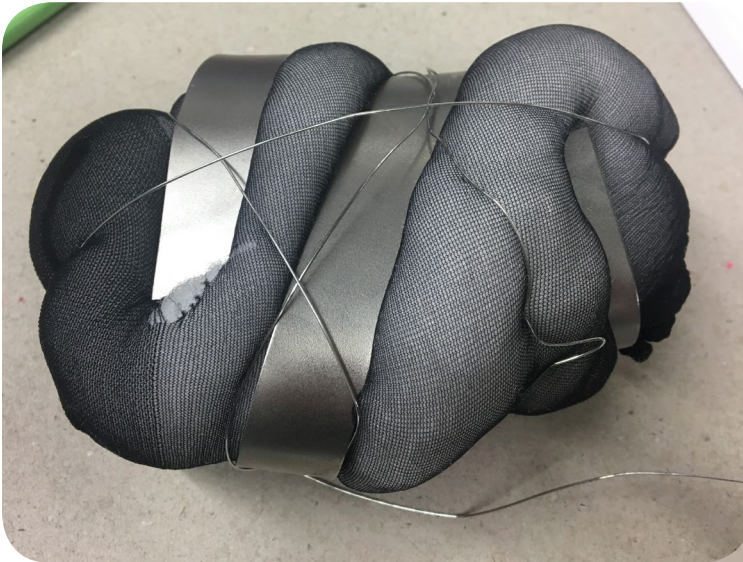


Activity 3: As a group, identify verbal pain descriptions and use any of the available materials to visually re-create the feeling, action, motion etc.

Pins stuck into twisted and roughly stuck together plasticine representing 'fused insides' and 'stabbing pains'

The outcomes

Pain as physical damage was the most common visual representation of pain. The participants used hard vs. soft materials to demonstrate their internal pain by replicating actions such as strangling, wringing, constricting, stabbing, pinching, pulling, piercing, cutting etc.



Pain as physical properties of elements was most commonly represented through use of balloons or materials stuffed tightly inside something else. This demonstrates feelings of bloatedness, ballooning and tightness inside the abdomen. As a group, we also discussed pain as a searing hot or burning sensation, which we represented through use of a torch.



"It's fusing itself and it's angry and it's inflated and it's contracting and it's doing all sorts of horrible things"



"Everything inside feels like it's expanding to the point where it's going to tear"



"I have an inflated balloon inside my tummy at all times"

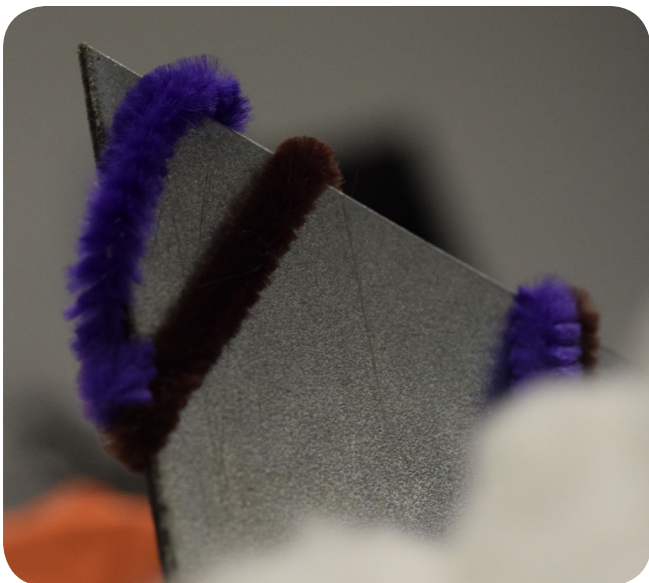
A new discovery: Pain as a living entity. During the materials workshop, our participants used a metaphor we hadn't heard previously: endometriosis pain as a living entity. Pain was described as someone or something you need to 'protect' because you do not want to anger it.

"Don't make it worse, don't make it angry, do everything you can to **protect** it"

"You don't want to inflame it even more"

"I was waiting for it to come back. I was frightened all the time. I was so fearful..."

"It's almost like you need to **protect** the badness so that you don't anger it further"



One of our participants used a jagged piece of metal (hard) wrapped in pipe cleaners (soft) to visually represent 'protecting the badness'

"the soft thing wraps around the sharp thing, almost to kind of **protect** it, you feel like you need something there to **protect** you. For years I literally walked round with a hot water bottle attached to me or a heat pad or a something and it felt like it was there because it helped but it was there as a form of **protection** as well, a barrier"

Pain as a transformative force. Although we saw no visual representations of pain as a transformative force, we repeatedly heard instances where women couldn't remember what actually happened or remember what they felt when their pain was at its most severe, suggesting that they were outside of themselves.

"I have to trust my recollection of the
pain"

"It's not a vivid recollection because
you're not there, you're not
experiencing it in that same way
anymore"

"It's so hard to describe
something retrospectively"

"Recalling pain is hard because you're
no longer in the moment"

As a group, we discussed how this could be compared to childbirth and the idea that women are 'pre-programmed' to forget very intense states of pain in order to be able to live through it again. However, it was clear from the workshop that being given the time to talk and reflect as a group helped remember and identify pain they had previously experienced.

"Those very intense states, to protect yourself, so that you can carry on living your life probably and go through it again. Because you will go through those phases again. It's really difficult to put yourself back in that position, **but I suppose we've talked about it a lot so that helps you remember what that thing is.**"



Did this approach help articulate pain?

At the end of the workshop, we discussed whether or not the materials had been useful in helping articulate pain more clearly. All of the participants agreed that the materials had helped them reflect on their pain in a new way and even revealed aspects of their pain that they had previously not been able to explore verbally.

The participants re-iterated how difficult describing pain can be, particularly when pain is at its most severe, as in that moment, your mind almost 'shuts down' to protect itself. Through group discussion, reflection and using the materials as a tool to support and demonstrate your thinking, the workshop helped the participants gain a tangible hold of their own pain.

"It's good to be able to do it, to have that **tangible aspect** to it and to **visualise it** as well has been really valuable, definitely"

"For me, it [the final sculpture] goes alongside a conversation we've had today. It's like a **map of a conversation**, it's like an **illustration of a conversation**"

"That method of working with things **reveals stuff**, it's a different communication with yourself and what comes out of that can often be quite revealing about ways that you're thinking about things that **you didn't really explore verbally**"

"They [the materials] have **pulled out things that we've maybe not considered before**"

"I think that there's things there that through talking about them and describing them as you're doing them, have **made me understand my thoughts about it**"

The Language of Endometriosis project will continue to conduct research and will run more workshops such as these in the hope that we will develop a linguistic toolkit that will help women adequately describe their endometriosis pain.

For further information and support with endometriosis, please visit www.endometrios-uk.org

*This booklet presents visual
representations of endometriosis
pain through use of materials.*



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